

Class of '09 Brass Rat Revealed, Hidden "08" Seen in Ring Design

By Swetha Kambhampati
STAFF REPORTER

The Brass Rat 2009 Ring Premiere held last Friday evening marked the release of the design of the Class of 2009 Ring, which features several unique aspects, such as female and male signs on the beaver's pocket watch and an inscription of "punt," which can be read as "tool" upside down. In addition, the presence of an accidental "08" behind the beaver in the ring's bezel has posed a controversy.

The budget for this year's ring was \$70,000, marking an increase

of \$20,000 from last year's. Amy C. Gilpin '09, the Ring Committee treasurer, said that this is partially because of an increase in the cost of gold. The additional money will also go toward planning the Ring Delivery, the event where students receive their rings.

Arjun Naskar '09, the historian of the Ring Committee said, "The Class of 2007 ring had some controversy. So to balance that out, the Class of 2008 made a very traditional ring. We took a middle path that included a lot of the traditional features that have been used for the last four or

five years such as hacking, the motto 'IHTFP,' and 'punt,' and 'tool,' and gave it our own twist."

Regarding the controversy over the "08" on the bezel, Colleen P. Mosley '09, the Vice Chair of the Ring Committee, said, "We didn't even notice it. It was just the way that Walker and Building 2 were drawn. It was completely unintentional."

In addition to the controversy over the hidden "08," the 2009 ring committee also accidentally leaked

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Sunita Darbe '09, Christopher J. Varenhorst '09, Danbee Kim '09, and C. Kiersten Pollard '09 (left to right) examine the newly-revealed rings after the Class of 2009 Ring Premiere.

Fatal Levels of Sedative Found in Zhou's Autopsy

By Nick Semenkovich
STAFF REPORTER

Toxicology studies for Mengyao "May" Zhou '04 found toxic levels of diphenhydramine, a sedative and antihistamine, in her system. Zhou, a Stanford University graduate student, was found dead in the trunk of her car on Jan. 25 of an apparent suicide.

Zhou's toxicology tests detected diphenhydramine at 6.15 mg/L, exceeding the "toxic range" of 1-5 mg/L, according to a Sonoma County Coroner's Office press release. Diphenhydramine is an ingredient in over-the-counter drugs such as Benadryl and sleep aids.

"No other common acidic, neutral or basic drugs [were] detected," the press release stated. "No blood or

urine ethyl alcohol [was] detected."

Despite the completion of an autopsy, the Santa Rosa police have not yet ruled on the cause of death or commented on the role of diphenhydramine in Zhou's death.

Yitong Zhou, May Zhou's father, is convinced his daughter did not commit suicide.

"Nobody believes she killed herself... just the police," he said to *The Mercury News*. Yitong Zhou also told the paper he was considering hiring his own forensics expert and exhuming his daughter's body.

Zhou's father has also questioned the source of the diphenhydramine, saying there are no receipts showing its purchase. "The tests don't mean anything if you can't find out where [the drugs] came from," he told *The Palo Alto Daily News*.

Yitong Zhou is also suspicious of the transfer of "a large sum of money" on the night his daughter died, he told *The Palo Alto Daily News*. "This means she didn't think she would die. Otherwise, why would she move the money?"

The investigation into Zhou's death still remains open.

Sherley Calls Hunger Strike Off After Day Twelve of Protesting

By Joyce Kwan
ASSOCIATE NEWS EDITOR

After 12 days of ingesting only water, vitamin supplements, and electrolytes, Associate Professor James L. Sherley of the biological engineering department ended his hunger strike last Friday, Feb. 16. Sherley, who is African American, went on a hunger strike to protest his tenure denial, which he claimed was tarnished by racial discrimination.

After ending his strike at noon on Friday, Sherley issued a public statement thanking his supporters and stating that he ended his strike in "celebration of the attention that has been brought to bear on issues of equity, diversity, and justice at MIT and in higher education."

He also said in his statement that his "demands are still on the table."

MIT issued a statement as well, acknowledging that Sherley's "protest has focused attention on the effects that race may play in the hiring, advancement and experience of under-represented minority faculty."

MIT stated that it "bears responsibility for ensuring an environment in which all members of our diverse community feel welcome and respected," and that it "is fully committed" to ensure "comprehensive, fair and timely" grievance processes.

Last Thursday, Feb. 15, Sherley sent an e-mail to members of the MIT community urging them to boycott MIT's Martin Luther King Jr. Breakfast Celebration, which was to be held the next day, because of the "hypocrisy" of MIT's senior officers.

In the e-mail, Sherley compared actions of President Susan Hockfield and Provost L. Rafael Reif to "the water hoses, dogs, and billy-clubs of the civil rights struggles."

Sherley also stated in the e-mail that he "will not eat again until MIT's upper administration either admits that racism and obstruction of justice was a problem in my case and others, or works with my advocates to develop a fair and open process to decide the issue."

Chemistry Professor Keith A. Nelson sent an e-mail in response to Sherley's e-mail. Nelson wrote that his own acquaintance with some of the people whom Sherley criticized "does not suggest to me that they are so uniformly, blatantly, and relentlessly dishonest or outright evil as you indicate." Also, Nelson wrote, "however racist the motivations of our colleagues, any comparison between you and the victims of water hoses, dogs, and billy-clubs is sickening."

According to Sherley in his e-mail calling for boycott of the MLK breakfast, "some of the faculty are considering other tenured homes for me at MIT besides BE."

At the end of his public statement on Friday, Sherley urged MIT to "respond to the lines of communication and negotiation that have been in place for two weeks," referring to the span of his hunger strike. MIT stated that it "will continue to work toward resolution of our differences with Professor Sherley."

Complete statements from both Sherley and MIT are on page 19.



ROBERT C. GENS

Hackers placed a large yellow crank on the side of the Media Lab on Sunday, in the style of the crank that powers the "One Laptop Per Child" laptops that were developed at the lab. Smaller cranks were "installed" on various objects across campus. According to the hackers, between ninety and one hundred of the smaller cranks were deployed.

In Short

¶ Professor Victor Zue will become sole director of the Computer Science and Artificial Intelligence Laboratory lab, effective July 1. Zue has been co-director of CSAIL since 2003.

¶ Tomorrow's faculty meeting will include more discussion on the Report from the Task Force on the Undergraduate Education Commons. A "New Initiative on Racial Diversity" is also on the agenda. The meeting will be at 3:30 p.m. in the Stata Center (Room 32-123).

Send news information and tips to
news@the-tech.mit.edu.

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